

Just a few years ago, any or all of the above would have been the kind of headlines that would have made for nice April Fool's Day prank articles. As of today they have all been realised.

In the end though, they are mere headlines, the reality behind them is a whole lot more nuanced than can be captured in a few words. Hopefully that nuance should become more apparent as you read further into this Fast Track.

There are some things that immediately stand out when it comes to Windows 10. First of all, what's with Windows 10 being free? Also what happened to Windows 9, and why is everyone saying that Windows 10 will be the last version of Windows?

Why Free

On first thought giving away Windows 10 for free seems like a huge loss of money for Microsoft, why would they do it? Why the sudden charity? What's next an open source Windows!

First of all, this is a new Microsoft, one that has been warming up to open source, to the extent that despite an open source version of Windows is still an impossibility at this point, it no longer feels like that will never happen.

Even so, giving Windows 10 away isn't an act of charity, it simply makes sense for Microsoft given their goals. Their goal being to unify the Windows platform such that all Windows devices run the same core OS. Imagine instead if Microsoft had announced a huge marketing budget of billions of dollars for their next OS, few people would bat an eyelid. What better way to get people to adopt a product than to give it away for free? Also, let's see where exactly Microsoft stands to lose this money.

Consider this fact, despite being around for a couple of years, Windows 8 only managed to achieve a meagre lead over Windows XP. Why?

The current batch of Windows users is made up of three kinds of users:

The first who purchased a new device and either got Windows 8 with it, or bought a retail copy separately and got Windows 8 / 8.1. The second batch of users are those who purchased a Windows 8 upgrade for Windows 7 or 8. And of course, as the good old saying goes, nothing is certain but death, taxes and piracy; the third group of users are those who pirated Windows 8.

So the potential adopters of Windows 10 are also likewise of three kinds, those purchasing a new device, those running an older versions of Windows on their device, and finally those who'll pirate the OS. The pirates always